

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Retail Associate and Cashier English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Retail sales associates, cashiers, fitting-room attendants, and shop-floor customer service staff.

All shops, transactions, stock records, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course covers frontline interactions, not retail strategy, merchandising management, financial advice, or universal consumer-law rules. Follow the employer's actual payment, privacy, safety, and returns procedures; refer exceptions and restricted decisions to the responsible staff.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Finding the item the shopper actually means

Confirm product variation before searching for stock.

02 Comparing fit, materials, and label information

Use label evidence instead of broad claims about quality.

03 Resolving shelf prices and offer conditions

Distinguish an average bundle price from a single-item price.

04 Checking the basket and payment status

Explain the correction and verify the revised quantity and total.

05 Discussing returns and exchanges at the counter

Explain the stated exchange conditions without promising an unavailable replacement.

06 Explaining local stock and collection status

Separate order acknowledgment from pickup readiness.

07 Managing queues and offering practical assistance

Offer a concrete access option without making assumptions about the shopper.

08 Handing over a till and an unfinished query

Give amounts, open checks, and a named next owner.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Finding the item the shopper actually means

Confirm product variation before searching for stock.

SITUATION

A shopper asks for the blue shirt in an advertisement. The ad shows two blue shirts: linen L214 and cotton C218. The shopper wants a medium cotton shirt; local availability has not been checked. Confirm item and size before discussing stock.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

stock-keeping unit - An identifier for a particular product variation, often abbreviated SKU, such as a specific shirt size and color.

barcode - A machine-readable pattern used to identify an item when scanned.

size range - The set of sizes in which a product is offered.

fitting room - A designated shop space where customers can try on clothing.

Useful word combinations

check the item code: compare the exact product identifier

find the right size: locate the variation the shopper requests

point out the fitting room: show where clothing can be tried on

narrow down the choice: reduce options by clarifying the shopper's needs

LESSON 01 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Ask one question that narrows the search

3. Notice the language

Color alone may describe several items. Use material, code, and size to distinguish them without claiming availability prematurely.

Do you mean the ___ or the ___?

The item code is ___; is that the one?

I'll check this store's stock in ___.

Compare this wording: The blue one is over there.

Clearer: Do you mean the cotton C218 or the linen L214?

The question identifies the ambiguity instead of giving uncertain directions.

4. Check the language

1. Shopper: The advertisement has two blue shirts. Mine is cotton, not linen.

Associate: You mean ____.

A. C218

B. L214

C. both advertised shirts

D. the linen variation

2. Cashier: This label identifies one color-and-size variation.

Associate: That is its ____.

A. size range

B. product family

C. department name

D. stock-keeping unit

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two blue shirts in one advertisement

An associate clarifies a shopper's request on the sales floor.

01 • Associate: There are two blue shirts in that advertisement. Do you mean the cotton or linen version?

02 • Shopper: The cotton one, please. I want a medium, but I can't find it here.

03 • Associate: The cotton code is C218. Let me confirm that against the item pictured on your phone.

04 • Shopper: Yes, that's the one. The linen shirt beside it looks almost the same color.

05 • Associate: I'll check the stock-keeping unit for medium C218, so we get that exact variation.

06 • Shopper: Does being in the advertisement mean you definitely have that size in this branch today?

07 • Associate: No. The advertisement identifies the product; local stock needs a separate check for your variation.

08 • Shopper: Thanks. Could I see a large for comparison if the medium isn't available here?

09 • Associate: We can discuss that after checking, but I won't substitute a different size without asking.

10 • Shopper: That's fine. Medium cotton C218 is my first choice; the other size is only a possibility.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The code is clearer than the display location

A shopper brings a loose item from a mixed display.

01 • Associate: You found this near the jackets, but its label identifies it as a lightweight overshirt.

02 • Shopper: I thought everything on that rail belonged to the same range and fitted similarly.

03 • Associate: Items can be moved. Let's check the product code and size label on this one.

04 • Shopper: The code is O316 and the label says small. Does it come in a medium?

05 • Associate: The listed size range includes medium; that doesn't yet confirm one is in this shop.

06 • Shopper: Could you check while I compare how the small feels in the fitting room?

07 • Associate: Certainly. The fitting rooms are beside the mirror, and I'll search this exact code.

08 • Shopper: Please don't bring a similar jacket instead. I need the same material and style.

09 • Associate: I'll look for medium O316, and tell you clearly if that variation isn't available.

10 • Shopper: Great. The label gives us a more precise starting point than where I found it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A gift request without a guessed size

An associate helps a shopper buying a gift.

01 • Associate: What do you know about the item they liked: its color, material, or exact code?

02 • Shopper: Only that it was a green sweater in your window. I don't know their size.

03 • Associate: There are two green styles there. Could you point to the one they mentioned?

04 • Shopper: The one with the textured front. I don't want you to guess their size from a photograph.

05 • Associate: I won't. We can identify the style now and leave the size choice open.

06 • Shopper: Could I see the size range and the stated gift exchange terms before deciding?

07 • Associate: Yes. I'll show both, without treating an available range as proof every size is stocked.

08 • Shopper: That would help. I may ask them for a size before buying anything today.

09 • Associate: This is the textured style, code K420. You can use that code when you return.

10 • Shopper: I'll do that. Identifying the item first saves us choosing the wrong green sweater.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Finding the item the shopper actually means

A shopper asks for the blue shirt in an advertisement. The ad shows two blue shirts: linen L214 and cotton C218. The shopper wants a medium cotton shirt; local availability has not been checked. Confirm item and size before discussing stock.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: want the medium cotton blue shirt, not the linen shirt; have not seen local stock information.

Second round: The shopper points at the wrong picture while repeating the cotton code. Clarify before searching.

Scenario 2 | A barcode belongs to the packaging, not the loose item

A shopper presents a mug inside a box marked for a larger model. The mug base shows M12; the box shows M18. No sale has been entered.

Role A: Associate: compare the two identifiers and find the matching label.

Role B: Shopper: want the smaller M12 mug and its correct price.

Possible opening: Can you scan the box? I put the mug in it myself.

Success checks

- Identify the mug actually selected.
- Keep the mismatched box separate.
- Confirm the exact item before quoting a price.

Add a complication: The shopper assumes the larger model's displayed price applies.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Comparing fit, materials, and label information

Use label evidence instead of broad claims about quality.

SITUATION

A shopper needs a machine-washable jacket. Jacket A is unlined and its label permits machine washing; B is lined and its label states dry-clean only. Both cost \$60. Compare the stated care requirements without inventing comfort or durability claims.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

care label - The attached label stating the manufacturer's garment-care information.

lining - An inner layer of fabric inside a garment or bag.

seam - The join where pieces of fabric are stitched together.

fit - How a garment's shape and size sit on the wearer.

Useful word combinations

check the care label: read the supplied care information

compare the fit: discuss how two garments sit on the wearer

allow room through the shoulders: describe the space available in the upper garment

check the seam position: identify where a stitched join sits

LESSON 02 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Compare the same practical requirement

3. Notice the language

Price, lining, fit, and care are different features. Identify the deciding requirement and avoid extending the label's meaning beyond what it states.

Both cost ___, but the labels say ___.

This matches your requirement for ___.

The label doesn't establish ___.

Compare this wording: The lined one is better.

Clearer: The lined one requires dry cleaning; the other matches your machine-wash requirement.

The comparison uses the shopper's criterion rather than an undefined quality claim.

4. Check the language

1. Shopper: Which one matches my machine-wash requirement?

Associate: ____.

A. Jacket B

B. Both jackets equally

C. Neither jacket

D. Jacket A

2. Shopper: What is the extra fabric inside this jacket called?

Associate: The ____.

A. outer shell

B. care label

C. lining

D. seam

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The care requirement decides the first comparison

An associate compares two jackets with a shopper.

01 • Associate: Both jackets cost sixty dollars. Is care, warmth, or fit your first priority today?

02 • Shopper: Care. I need something labelled for machine washing because I travel frequently for work.

03 • Associate: Jacket A's label permits that. Jacket B is lined and marked dry-clean only.

04 • Shopper: Then the similar price doesn't mean they have the same care requirements at all.

05 • Associate: Correct. The labels give different instructions, even though both jackets share the same displayed price.

06 • Shopper: I'll consider A first. Does being unlined automatically mean it will fit more loosely?

07 • Associate: No. Lining and fit are separate features; trying it on will help you compare.

08 • Shopper: May I try the medium and large rather than choose from the label alone?

09 • Associate: Certainly. I'll bring both available sizes so you can compare the shoulder and body fit.

10 • Shopper: That's useful. The care label narrows the choice, but I still need the right fit.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Sleeve length and body fit are different

An associate checks a shopper's concern outside the fitting room.

01 • Associate: Which part doesn't feel right: the body, the shoulders, or the length of the sleeves?

02 • Shopper: The body feels fine, but the sleeves cover more of my hands than I expected.

03 • Associate: So going up a size may not address the issue you're describing with sleeve length.

04 • Shopper: Exactly. I don't want more room everywhere just because the sleeve shape isn't suitable.

05 • Associate: We have another cut in the same listed size. Would you like to compare that?

06 • Shopper: Yes, as long as it's clear we're comparing a different cut, not identical sizing across styles.

07 • Associate: Certainly. Size labels don't guarantee the same fit in every design or product range.

08 • Shopper: Could you show me where the shoulder seam sits on each one for comparison?

09 • Associate: Yes, here is the stitched join on each garment. Tell me which feels more comfortable.

10 • Shopper: The second style suits me better. I'll check its care label before making my decision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Reading a label without inventing a guarantee

A shopper asks about an unfamiliar fabric-care symbol.

01 • Shopper: Does this label mean the sweater will never shrink, whatever washing method I use?

02 • Associate: No. The label gives care information; it doesn't make an unlimited guarantee about every method.

03 • Shopper: Could you help me find the manufacturer's written explanation rather than guess at the symbol?

04 • Associate: Yes. This item has a printed care explanation on the reverse of the label.

05 • Shopper: I see it now. The instructions are more specific than what I assumed from the picture.

06 • Associate: Would you like to compare another item with care requirements that better fit your routine?

07 • Shopper: Please. I'd prefer a clearly labelled option I can maintain without changing my usual arrangements.

08 • Associate: This alternative has different stated care information. Let's compare the labels before discussing its fit.

09 • Shopper: That helps. I won't treat your explanation as permission to ignore the manufacturer's instructions.

10 • Associate: Exactly. We can clarify the wording while keeping the actual care directions with the product.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Comparing fit, materials, and label information

A shopper needs a machine-washable jacket. Jacket A is unlined and its label permits machine washing; B is lined and its label states dry-clean only. Both cost \$60. Compare the stated care requirements without inventing comfort or durability claims.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: need machine washing, have a sixty-dollar budget, and still need to check fit.

Second round: The shopper assumes identical prices mean identical care requirements. Return to the two labels.

Scenario 2 | One bag has pockets, the other has lining

Two bags cost \$24. A has a lining but no internal pocket; B has one internal pocket but no lining. The shopper needs a pocket for keys.

Role A: Associate: compare the stated features without equating lining with storage.

Role B: Shopper: prioritize an internal key pocket over lining.

Possible opening: Does lined mean it has a pocket inside?

Success checks

- Explain lining versus pocket.
- Identify B as matching the stated pocket need.
- Avoid unsupported durability claims.

Add a complication: The shopper assumes the more structured appearance proves stronger construction.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Resolving shelf prices and offer conditions

Distinguish an average bundle price from a single-item price.

SITUATION

A shopper has one juice bottle priced at \$3. The shelf offer says two qualifying bottles for \$5; single bottles remain \$3. The shopper expects one bottle for \$2.50. Explain the quantity condition without treating half the bundle price as the single-item offer.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

shelf-edge label - A label beside displayed goods stating the item description and price.

unit price - A price expressed per standard amount, such as per liter, for comparison.

multibuy offer - A promotion requiring the purchase of a stated number of qualifying items.

price check - A request to verify an item's applicable price when information is unclear.

Useful word combinations

match the label to the item: compare product description and code

read the offer conditions: identify qualifying quantity and items

compare the unit prices: use the same standard quantity for both products

request a price check: ask a colleague to verify a disputed price

LESSON 03 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Explain the condition that changes the price

3. Notice the language

Use the offer's quantity condition and the same price basis. Don't infer a universal pricing rule from this fictional promotion.

The offer applies when you buy ____.

One item remains ____ under these terms.

That is the average, not ____.

Compare this wording: They're two-fifty each.

Clearer: Two cost five under the offer; one alone costs three.

The quantity condition stays attached to the discounted price.

4. Check the language

1. Shopper: I have only one bottle. Is it two-fifty?

Cashier: Under this offer, one bottle costs ____.

A. five dollars

B. one dollar fifty

C. three dollars

D. two dollars fifty

2. Shopper: These packs have different amounts. How can I compare on the same quantity basis?

Associate: Compare their ____.

A. multibuy quantities alone

B. unit prices

C. package totals alone

D. advertised percentage discounts alone

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

One bottle is not half the bundle offer

A cashier explains the fictional juice promotion.

01 • Cashier: You have one qualifying bottle. Its single price is three dollars under this offer.

02 • Shopper: The shelf says two for five, so I expected this one to be two-fifty.

03 • Cashier: This multibuy offer requires two qualifying bottles. Then each would average two-fifty.

04 • Shopper: I only need one. Are you saying the displayed deal doesn't change its individual price?

05 • Cashier: That's right for these stated terms. One remains three; two qualifying bottles total five.

06 • Shopper: Could I add any flavor, or does the second bottle need the same offer label?

07 • Cashier: Both must qualify. We can check the shelf label for the flavor you're considering.

08 • Shopper: Then I'll keep just this one today. I don't want an extra bottle I won't use.

09 • Cashier: Certainly. I'll leave the quantity at one and confirm the three-dollar price before payment.

10 • Shopper: Three dollars for this one is fine. Please leave the extra bottle off my purchase.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The label belongs to the smaller pack

An associate checks a price complaint at a shelf.

01 • Associate: Let's match the shelf-edge label to your pack before deciding which price applies.

02 • Shopper: I picked it from this space, so I assumed the label underneath referred to it.

03 • Associate: The label describes a six-pack, while your box contains twelve and has a different code.

04 • Shopper: That explains the mismatch. Can you find the displayed price for this actual twelve-pack?

05 • Associate: Yes. I'll check the matching code rather than assume the six-pack price applies.

06 • Shopper: Please don't replace my box with six just to match the lower label I mentioned.

07 • Associate: I won't. You're asking for a price check on the twelve-pack, not a substitution.

08 • Shopper: Exactly. Once I know the correct total, I can choose which quantity I want.

09 • Associate: The matching twelve-pack label says nine dollars. Would you like to keep it or compare the six?

10 • Shopper: I'll keep twelve at nine. Thank you for identifying the mismatch before I reached checkout.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A larger pack is not automatically the cheaper choice

A shopper compares two fictional quantities of detergent.

01 • Associate: The one-liter bottle is four dollars; the two-liter bottle is seven dollars today.

02 • Shopper: So the bigger one costs more overall but less for each liter, correct?

03 • Associate: Yes. The smaller is four per liter, while the larger works out at three-fifty per liter.

04 • Shopper: I only have five dollars to spend. The better unit price doesn't fit that limit.

05 • Associate: Then the smaller bottle meets your total budget, although its price per liter is higher.

06 • Shopper: I appreciate that distinction. I don't want to be pushed toward a larger purchase just for a ratio.

07 • Associate: Of course. Unit price is one comparison; the amount you need and can spend also matter.

08 • Shopper: I'll take one liter. Does that displayed four dollars depend on buying anything else?

09 • Associate: No, the supplied price is for one bottle without an additional purchase condition.

10 • Shopper: That's the one I want. Please keep the comparison tied to today's displayed prices.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Resolving shelf prices and offer conditions

A shopper has one juice bottle priced at \$3. The shelf offer says two qualifying bottles for \$5; single bottles remain \$3. The shopper expects one bottle for \$2.50. Explain the quantity condition without treating half the bundle price as the single-item offer.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: want just one bottle unless the two-bottle offer clearly fits your needs.

Second round: The second bottle is a nonqualifying flavor. Explain that quantity and qualifying item both matter.

Scenario 2 | An offer starts tomorrow

The shelf sign states a \$12 promotion beginning Saturday. It is Friday and today's confirmed price is \$15. The shopper misread the starting date.

Role A: Associate: explain the date condition and offer a price check if needed.

Role B: Shopper: willing to return Saturday but want to know whether stock is guaranteed.

Possible opening: I thought the twelve-dollar offer was active today.

Success checks

- State today's and the advertised start date accurately.
- Distinguish price terms from stock availability.
- Avoid promising an unverified reservation.

Add a complication: The shopper assumes returning tomorrow guarantees stock at that price.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Checking the basket and payment status

Explain the correction and verify the revised quantity and total.

SITUATION

Two \$8 mugs were scanned, but the shopper has only one. There are no additional charges in this exercise. Payment has not begun. Acknowledge the duplicate, correct the recorded quantity through the store's checkout process, and confirm \$8 before payment.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

point-of-sale system - The store equipment and software used to record purchases and process checkout, often abbreviated POS.

subtotal - The total for entered items before any separately applied tax, fee, or discount adjustments.

tender - A method or form of payment offered for a purchase, such as cash or a card.

receipt - A record of a completed transaction showing relevant purchase and payment details.

Useful word combinations

review the basket: check items and quantities before payment

remove a duplicate scan: correct an item entered twice

confirm the amount due: state the total still requiring payment

check transaction status: establish whether payment has completed

LESSON 04 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Correct the basket before taking payment

3. Notice the language

Name the exact duplicate instead of saying the register is wrong generally. Keep a basket correction separate from a refund after payment.

The basket shows ___, but you have ___.

Payment hasn't started, so this is ___.

The revised quantity is ___ and the total is ___.

Compare this wording: I'll refund that extra one.

Clearer: Payment hasn't started; I'll correct the duplicate entry before you pay.

A refund would imply money had already been paid.

4. Check the language

1. Shopper: Have I already paid for the extra mug?

Cashier: No, this is a basket correction, not a ____.

A. subtotal review

B. refund

C. quantity check

D. price display

2. Shopper: You've removed the duplicate mug, but I haven't paid yet. Is the purchase finished?

Cashier: The quantity is corrected; the payment ____.

A. has not yet been taken

B. has already been refunded

C. has now been completed

D. was taken before the correction

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

One mug entered twice

A cashier corrects the item count before payment. In this fictional shop, one mug costs eight dollars and no other charges apply.

01 • Cashier: The point-of-sale system shows two mugs at eight dollars each. Did you choose two?

02 • Shopper: No, I have only one mug. I think the barcode was scanned twice just now.

03 • Cashier: You're right. I'm sorry about the duplicate entry; payment hasn't begun for this basket.

04 • Shopper: Then I don't need a refund, because I haven't actually paid sixteen dollars yet?

05 • Cashier: Correct. I'll correct the basket quantity through the checkout system before taking any payment.

06 • Shopper: Could you show the updated line so I can check that only one remains?

07 • Cashier: Here it is: one mug at eight dollars. Please check the quantity on this line.

08 • Shopper: That's correct. I was worried the correction might remove the whole purchase by mistake.

09 • Cashier: The mug is still in your basket; only the duplicate entry has been removed.

10 • Shopper: I can see that now. Let's continue with the eight-dollar total for one mug.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A notification is not the register's final status

A cashier responds when a card-payment screen pauses.

01 • Cashier: The checkout hasn't shown a final payment result yet. Please wait while I check its status.

02 • Shopper: My phone has a banking notification. Doesn't that prove the sale is complete on your side?

03 • Cashier: It may relate to the payment attempt, but it doesn't confirm our checkout's final status.

04 • Shopper: I don't want to pay twice because two screens are giving different impressions.

05 • Cashier: I understand. I won't describe it as completed or ask for another attempt without checking.

06 • Shopper: Could you ask the supervisor to look at the transaction rather than guess from my phone?

07 • Cashier: Yes. I'll keep this sale reference with the query and explain the screen hasn't finalized.

08 • Shopper: Thank you. Please don't ask me to share account passwords to help with the check.

09 • Cashier: We don't need your password. The supervisor will review the store-side transaction information.

10 • Shopper: Then I'll wait for that result before choosing any next payment step with you.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A receipt choice before leaving

After a cash purchase, a cashier clarifies a shopper's preferred receipt format.

01 • Cashier: Your purchase is complete. Would you prefer the available paper receipt or a digital receipt?

02 • Shopper: Paper, please. I don't want to supply an email address just to record this purchase.

03 • Cashier: That's fine. I can print the receipt without adding you to a mailing list.

04 • Shopper: Thank you. Does choosing paper change the store's stated return terms for this item?

05 • Cashier: No. The receipt format doesn't alter the terms displayed for this purchase here.

06 • Shopper: Could you point out which line identifies the item, in case I need it later?

07 • Cashier: Certainly. This line shows the product description, quantity, and amount for your selected item.

08 • Shopper: I see cash listed as the tender below. That isn't an extra item, is it?

09 • Cashier: Exactly. It's payment information, not an extra product charge added to your basket.

10 • Shopper: That's clear. I'll keep the paper receipt with the product packaging when I get home.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Checking the basket and payment status

Two \$8 mugs were scanned, but the shopper has only one. There are no additional charges in this exercise. Payment has not begun. Acknowledge the duplicate, correct the recorded quantity through the store's checkout process, and confirm \$8 before payment.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: have one mug; point out the duplicate before payment.

Second round: The shopper sees a payment notification from an earlier purchase. Keep it separate from this unpaid basket.

Scenario 2 | The quantity was correct but the size was not

A shopper buys one medium shirt. The basket shows one large because a loose tag from another item was scanned. The selected medium is C218-M; the mistakenly scanned large tag is C218-L. The prices are equal, and payment has not started.

Role A: Cashier: correct the identified variation without claiming a price difference.

Role B: Shopper: need the receipt to identify the actual medium shirt.

Possible opening: The total is right, but the description says large.

Success checks

- Distinguish price accuracy from item accuracy.
- Confirm the medium item code.
- Check the corrected record before payment.

Add a complication: The shopper assumes equal prices mean the item record need not be corrected.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Discussing returns and exchanges at the counter

Explain the stated exchange conditions without promising an unavailable replacement.

SITUATION

In this fictional store, an unused shirt with tags and a receipt can be exchanged within thirty days. The shopper bought it ten days ago and wants a larger size. A receipt is present; larger-size stock remains unchecked. Explain eligibility and the stock uncertainty without stating universal return rights.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

proof of purchase - A receipt or other evidence the store accepts to establish where and when an item was bought.

exchange - Replacing a purchased item with another under the applicable store terms.

refund - Money returned for a purchase under the applicable decision and payment arrangements.

store credit - Value issued for use at the store rather than money returned to the original payment method.

Useful word combinations

check the return terms: read the conditions applying to the purchase

bring proof of purchase: provide the accepted purchase record

exchange for another size: replace the item with a different size

refer an exception request: ask the responsible person to review a request outside stated terms

LESSON 05 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Separate policy eligibility from available stock

3. Notice the language

A qualifying return does not create stock. Check the purchase conditions and then the requested replacement separately.

Under this store's terms, ___ qualifies for ___.

The remaining question is whether ___ is available.

A refund and store credit are different because ___.

Compare this wording: You're eligible, so the larger one is yours.

Clearer: The shirt qualifies for exchange; I'll check the larger size before confirming a replacement.

Eligibility alone does not establish local stock.

4. Check the language

1. Shopper: I want the same shirt in a larger size, not money back.

Cashier: You're requesting an ___.

A. exchange

B. account credit

C. item reservation

D. order cancellation

2. Shopper: Is store credit the same as money returned to my card?

Cashier: No, store credit is ___.

A. a card refund already completed

B. cash change from a sale

C. the original card payment

D. value to spend at the store

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The receipt qualifies; the size still needs checking

A cashier handles a shirt exchange.

01 • Cashier: Your receipt shows this shirt was bought ten days ago. Are you looking for another size?

02 • Shopper: Yes, one size larger. It's unused and still has the tags attached to it.

03 • Cashier: That meets this store's stated thirty-day exchange terms. I'll check whether large is available.

04 • Shopper: I'd like the same green, not a different color simply because it's easier to find.

05 • Cashier: I'll search for large in green using this item code. May I keep the receipt here?

06 • Shopper: Of course. I have the shirt with me, so you can compare the labels.

07 • Cashier: The stockroom colleague has found one large green shirt. Would you like to check the fit?

08 • Shopper: Yes, please. I don't want to exchange it twice because I guessed the size again.

09 • Cashier: The fitting room is free. I'll keep this transaction open while you try that one.

10 • Shopper: I'll be back shortly. Please keep my original shirt and receipt together at the counter.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A gift without the original price receipt

A shopper asks what a gift receipt can support.

01 • Cashier: Do you have any proof of purchase with the scarf you'd like to return?

02 • Shopper: I have a gift receipt. I don't have the buyer's payment card or full receipt.

03 • Cashier: For this store's stated gift terms, it can support an exchange or store credit after checking eligibility.

04 • Shopper: Would store credit send the money back to the person who bought the scarf?

05 • Cashier: No, it would give you value to spend here; a refund is a different arrangement.

06 • Shopper: I see. I would rather choose another scarf today if one suits me.

07 • Cashier: Let's check the gift receipt and item first, then you can look at the available scarves.

08 • Shopper: Please don't tell me the original price aloud. The gift receipt deliberately leaves it off.

09 • Cashier: I'll handle the check discreetly and explain the available options without discussing the buyer's details.

10 • Shopper: Thanks. I'll start with the blue scarves once you've confirmed the exchange can proceed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A request outside the stated window

A cashier responds to an exception request.

01 • Cashier: The receipt date is outside this store's thirty-day change-of-mind return window. What happened with the purchase?

02 • Shopper: I was traveling and couldn't come back sooner. The item is unused, with its tags.

03 • Cashier: I can ask the supervisor to review those circumstances, but I can't approve an exception myself.

04 • Shopper: Could you tell them I tried calling last week? I have the call time here.

05 • Cashier: Yes. I'll pass on that detail and your request, without treating the review as approval.

06 • Shopper: I'd like to speak with them directly if possible. I can wait a few minutes.

07 • Cashier: The supervisor can speak with you here after finishing another query.

08 • Shopper: Please keep my receipt nearby. I don't want to explain everything again from the beginning.

09 • Cashier: I'll keep the receipt with it and summarize the date, condition, and your travel explanation.

10 • Shopper: Thank you. I understand the decision hasn't been made; I'd just like the circumstances heard.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Discussing returns and exchanges at the counter

In this fictional store, an unused shirt with tags and a receipt can be exchanged within thirty days. The shopper bought it ten days ago and wants a larger size. A receipt is present; larger-size stock remains unchecked. Explain eligibility and the stock uncertainty without stating universal return rights.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: bought the unused tagged shirt ten days ago, have the receipt, and need the next size up.

Second round: The larger size is unavailable. Ask about other stated options rather than invent an exception.

Scenario 2 | Different item, different price

An eligible exchange involves a \$20 shirt. The shopper selects a different \$26 style. The fictional store permits this exchange with a \$6 additional payment. Stock is confirmed.

Role A: Cashier: explain the six-dollar difference before proceeding.

Role B: Shopper: can pay six but initially expects an even exchange.

Possible opening: Isn't an exchange always the same price?

Success checks

- Identify both item prices.
- Explain the difference rather than invent an exchange fee.
- Get the shopper's agreement before proceeding.

Add a complication: The shopper asks whether the six dollars is a fee rather than a price difference.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Explaining local stock and collection status

Separate order acknowledgment from pickup readiness.

SITUATION

A shopper's message acknowledges order R61 but is not a collection notification. One item is still being located. The collection colleague will update the shopper at 3:00, even if unresolved. Do not promise readiness or substitute another variation.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

sales floor - The part of a store where goods are displayed and customers shop.

stockroom - A store's storage area away from the main customer shopping space.

reserved item - An item held for a specified customer or purpose under stated conditions.

collection notification - A message telling a customer that an order is ready to collect under the stated arrangements; commonly called a pickup notification in US English.

Useful word combinations

check physical stock: confirm an item is actually present

locate the reserved item: find the goods assigned to the customer

wait for collection confirmation: avoid assuming an order acknowledgment means readiness

check the order reference: use the order identifier to distinguish similar requests

LESSON 06 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Tell the shopper what the message actually confirms

3. Notice the language

Use the message's wording and current physical status. An update time is not automatically a collection time.

This confirms ____, not ____.

One item is still ____.

Three o'clock is an update time, not ____.

Compare this wording: It's ordered, so it's ready.

Clearer: The order is acknowledged; one item is still being located.

The shopper receives the actual status instead of a broader implication.

4. Check the language

1. Shopper: Can I collect at three?

Associate: Three is the promised ____ time, not confirmed collection.

A. dispatch

B. purchase

C. refund

D. update

2. Shopper: It says we received your order. Is that the ready message?

Associate: No, it is an ____.

A. arrival confirmation

B. exchange approval

C. order acknowledgment

D. item substitution

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Received does not mean ready

An associate checks a shopper's order message.

01 • Associate: Could I see the message heading and order reference so I can check its status?

02 • Shopper: It says we received your order, reference R61. I thought I could collect it now.

03 • Associate: That's an acknowledgment, not the collection notification. One item is still being located.

04 • Shopper: I've come across town. Can someone give me a definite update rather than leave me waiting?

05 • Associate: The collection colleague will update you at three, even if the search isn't finished.

06 • Shopper: Does that mean everything will be on the collection shelf by three o'clock?

07 • Associate: I can't promise that. Three is the agreed update time; collection readiness is still unconfirmed.

08 • Shopper: Please don't switch the missing item to a different color just to finish the order.

09 • Associate: I'll pass that on. Your requested variation stays unchanged unless you agree otherwise.

10 • Shopper: Thanks. I'll wait nearby until three and check for the update before returning to the counter.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Stockroom search for an empty shelf

An associate helps a shopper whose item is not on display.

01 • Associate: The shelf is empty, but I can check whether this size is in the stockroom.

02 • Shopper: Your screen says two available. Doesn't that mean you can give me one immediately?

03 • Associate: It gives us a stock record to check, not the item's exact present location.

04 • Shopper: Could one be on the sales floor somewhere else, perhaps in the fitting-room returns?

05 • Associate: Possibly. I'll ask the colleague checking that area while I look in the stockroom.

06 • Shopper: Please search for the medium, not just any item from the same product range.

07 • Associate: I have the code for medium navy. I'll keep the size and color together in the request.

08 • Shopper: How long should I stay here before checking with you again about the search?

09 • Associate: I'll come back to this display in five minutes with an update, whether found or not.

10 • Shopper: That works. I'll look nearby, and you can tell me what you've actually located.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A reservation has an end time

An associate confirms a shopper's held item.

01 • Associate: The jacket is reserved under your name until six today. Is collection before then possible?

02 • Shopper: I can arrive at five-thirty. Do I need to pay again because you reserved it?

03 • Associate: No payment has been taken for this hold. You'll decide about the purchase at collection.

04 • Shopper: Could I try it on before deciding, or does reserving it commit me to buying it?

05 • Associate: Under today's stated hold arrangement, you can check the fit before deciding to purchase.

06 • Shopper: That's helpful. I might be delayed; should I assume the hold continues after six?

07 • Associate: Please contact us if you're delayed. I can't promise an extension beyond the agreed time.

08 • Shopper: Then I'll aim for five-thirty and call if that changes, rather than arrive after closing.

09 • Associate: The store closes at seven, but remember your item's agreed hold ends at six.

10 • Shopper: Understood. The two times are different; I'll keep the hold deadline in mind.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Explaining local stock and collection status

A shopper's message acknowledges order R61 but is not a collection notification. One item is still being located. The collection colleague will update the shopper at 3:00, even if unresolved. Do not promise readiness or substitute another variation.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: have an order acknowledgment and expected immediate pickup; need a truthful status.

Second round: The shopper asks whether choosing another color automatically makes the order ready. Keep substitution and readiness separate.

Scenario 2 | Two customers have the same surname

Two collection orders are labeled Chen. Their references are C41 and C47. The shopper presents C47; only C41 is on the front shelf, while C47 is being checked in back.

Role A: Associate: use the order reference rather than surname alone.

Role B: Shopper: need C47 and are willing to wait for its status.

Possible opening: That bag has my surname. Is it mine?

Success checks

- Confirm C47 as the required reference.
- Do not release C41 because of a matching surname.
- Give an accurate update on the search for C47.

Add a complication: The shopper says the bag's color looks familiar.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Managing queues and offering practical assistance

Offer a concrete access option without making assumptions about the shopper.

SITUATION

A shopper using a mobility aid says the current checkout is too narrow. An accessible checkout is open at lane four. Ask what help they prefer, explain the available route, and ask a colleague to preserve their place; do not touch their belongings or aid without permission.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

queue - A line of shoppers waiting for service; also called a line in US English.

accessible checkout - A checkout designed or arranged to support access needs, such as suitable space or counter height.

assistance call - A request to a colleague for help with a customer or store task.

checkout lane - A designated route and counter where shoppers complete purchases.

Useful word combinations

open another checkout: make another staffed payment point available

keep the aisle clear: preserve space for people to pass

offer assistance without assuming: ask what help the shopper wants

direct the next customer: guide the next person from the agreed queue order

LESSON 07 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Ask what help is wanted

3. Notice the language

Address the shopper directly and offer the available route. Ask before handling personal belongings or mobility equipment.

Would you prefer ___ or ___?

Lane ___ has ___.

May I help with ___?

Compare this wording: I'll move all your things for you.

Clearer: Would you like help with your basket, or would you prefer to keep it?

The question gives the shopper control over the help offered.

4. Check the language

1. Shopper: I need a wider checkout, but I'll carry my own bag.

Associate: So your request concerns ____.

A. home delivery

B. product availability

C. checkout access

D. bagging assistance

2. Shopper: I would like some assistance getting to lane four.

Associate: Could you tell me ____?

A. how you like me would to help

B. how you would like me to help

C. how would you like me to help

D. how you would like I to help

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A wider checkout without unwanted help

An associate responds to a shopper's access request.

01 • Associate: Lane four's accessible checkout is open and has wider space. Would that work better for you?

02 • Shopper: Yes, this one feels too narrow with my mobility aid. I can carry my bag myself.

03 • Associate: Of course. Would you prefer directions, or would you like someone to walk with you?

04 • Shopper: Directions, please. I can get there, but I don't want to lose my place in line.

05 • Associate: I'll ask the colleague at four to keep your place while we transfer the transaction.

06 • Shopper: Thank you. Is the route past the display wide enough, or should I go another way?

07 • Associate: The clear customer route runs along this side. I'll point out where it joins lane four.

08 • Shopper: I can see it now. Please leave my bag with me while I move over.

09 • Associate: My colleague is ready at four and will pick up your transaction.

10 • Shopper: Good. I'll go across now with my bag. Thank you for arranging that.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A price query blocks the lane

A cashier explains a delay without disclosing another shopper's purchase.

01 • Cashier: This checkout lane is waiting for a price check. Lane two can take the next customer.

02 • Shopper: I'm next in this queue. Will moving mean I have to start again behind someone else?

03 • Cashier: My colleague is opening it for the next person here, so you can go directly across.

04 • Shopper: What is the customer ahead buying that takes so long to check at the register?

05 • Cashier: We're waiting for a price check; I can't discuss another shopper's purchase.

06 • Shopper: Fair enough. I have a few fragile items; I'd rather keep them in this basket.

07 • Cashier: You can take the basket with you. My colleague will help with checkout at lane two.

08 • Shopper: Should I wait for an announcement, or can I move there once you point me over?

09 • Cashier: You can move now. Lane two is staffed and ready.

10 • Shopper: Thanks. I'll follow the clear aisle rather than cut through the closed lane beside it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An assistance call with a useful location

An associate requests help for a shopper on the sales floor.

01 • Associate: Assistance call for bedding, please: a customer needs a blue cover from the high shelf.

02 • Colleague: Which item and size do they want? There are several similar packages on that wall.

03 • Associate: It's the queen-size blue cover, code B24, on the top display shelf beside the pillows.

04 • Colleague: I'll come to that location. Have you promised the customer an exact collection time?

05 • Associate: No. I said I was requesting help and would stay here while we wait.

06 • Colleague: Good. Please keep the aisle available; I need room to assess the retrieval properly.

07 • Associate: The customer is waiting by the lower display, and nobody has attempted to climb for it.

08 • Colleague: I'm here now. Could you confirm the selected package with the customer before I begin?

09 • Associate: Yes. They pointed to B24 in queen, not the similar king-size package beside it.

10 • Colleague: I've confirmed that with them. I'll handle the retrieval using the store's equipment and procedures.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Managing queues and offering practical assistance

A shopper using a mobility aid says the current checkout is too narrow. An accessible checkout is open at lane four. Ask what help they prefer, explain the available route, and ask a colleague to preserve their place; do not touch their belongings or aid without permission.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: need a wider checkout and want to keep your own bag; prefer directions.

Second round: The next shopper questions why the transaction is moving. Explain briefly without disclosing personal details.

Scenario 2 | The shopper wants a seated pause

A shopper becomes tired in a long checkout queue and asks for a seat, without describing a medical emergency. A customer seat is available beside lane one; the cashier can call them at their turn.

Role A: Associate: offer the stated seat and preserve the shopper's place.

Role B: Shopper: want to keep your basket and hear when your turn arrives.

Possible opening: Could I sit down without losing my place?

Success checks

- Respond to the requested practical help.
- Keep the basket choice with the shopper.
- Confirm how the cashier will call the shopper.

Add a complication: A colleague starts asking personal health questions unrelated to arranging the seat.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Handing over a till and an unfinished query

Give amounts, open checks, and a named next owner.

SITUATION

At shift change, the expected drawer balance is \$180 and the recorded count is \$175. A second check has not occurred, and the cause is unknown. A price query for item P32 also remains open. The incoming supervisor accepts both checks; do not accuse anyone or describe a loss as proved.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

till float - The cash drawer starting balance provided for giving change, separate from the day's sales; often called the starting cash balance in US English.

cash discrepancy - A difference between counted cash and the amount expected from the store's records.

void - A cancelled transaction or item entry recorded by the point-of-sale system.

shift log - A store record of relevant events and open tasks passed between work shifts.

Useful word combinations

count against the record: compare counted amounts with expected figures

report a discrepancy: state the difference without inventing its cause

keep the transaction reference: preserve the identifier needed for a check

accept the follow-up: explicitly agree to handle an unfinished task

LESSON 08 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Hand over the observation, not an accusation

3. Notice the language

A discrepancy is a mismatch, not an established cause. Distinguish a cash check from a separate customer's price query.

The count is ___ against an expected ___.

The cause remains ___.

Can you take the follow-up on ___?

Compare this wording: Five dollars was stolen.

Clearer: The first count is five dollars below the expected amount; the cause hasn't been established.

The revised report states the evidence without accusing anyone.

4. Check the language

1. Supervisor: Expected cash is one-eighty, first count one-seventy-five.

Cashier: That's a ___ difference.

A. one-hundred-eighty-dollar

B. five-dollar

C. ten-dollar

D. one-hundred-seventy-five-dollar

2. Cashier: Does a void entry show an item was sold twice?

Supervisor: No, it records an entry that was ____.

A. cancelled

B. reserved

C. delivered

D. restocked

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A five-dollar difference needs checking

An outgoing cashier gives a shift-change report.

01 • Cashier: The first count is one-seventy-five against an expected one-eighty. The second check hasn't happened yet.

02 • Supervisor: That's a five-dollar cash discrepancy. Have we found an explanation, or does it still need checking?

03 • Cashier: Still unknown. I haven't attributed it to a sale, the till float, or any person.

04 • Supervisor: I'll take the second check through our cash-handling procedure. Is anything else waiting on this shift?

05 • Cashier: A customer price query for item P32 is open. The shelf label still needs confirmation.

06 • Supervisor: I'll take that separately. Please give me the item reference and the customer's stated price.

07 • Cashier: They expected twelve; the screen showed fourteen. No payment was taken while the query remained open.

08 • Supervisor: I've got it. I'll review the cash count and contact the floor colleague about P32.

09 • Cashier: Can you confirm both follow-ups are yours before I leave the counter?

10 • Supervisor: Confirmed. I'll record each result in the shift log rather than combine two unrelated issues.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The starting float is not sales revenue

A new cashier asks about a shift report.

01 • Cashier: The drawer started with forty dollars. Is everything in it now counted as sales?

02 • Supervisor: No. The till float is starting cash for change, so it isn't money from today's purchases.

03 • Cashier: I see the forty recorded here. I should keep that amount separate when describing the shift.

04 • Supervisor: Yes. Keep the float separate from sales on this report.

05 • Cashier: There's also a void for a mug. Does that entry mean the mug was returned after payment?

06 • Supervisor: No. This void cancelled the mug entry before the customer paid.

07 • Cashier: Then I'll refer to the recorded event as a void, not assume there was a refund.

08 • Supervisor: Correct. If a report line is unclear, ask about that transaction reference before changing its description.

09 • Cashier: I'll ask about reference V18 now. Its time overlaps with my break, so I didn't handle it.

10 • Supervisor: I'll check that reference with the colleague who did, and we'll leave its explanation open meanwhile.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An unfinished call needs a named owner

A cashier passes a callback request to the next shift.

01 • Cashier: A shopper called about receipt R82 and asked whether their exchange review had been completed.

02 • Incoming cashier: Do we have an answer, or am I taking over the task of checking it?

03 • Cashier: You're taking over the check. The supervisor hasn't recorded a decision in the shift log yet.

04 • Incoming cashier: I'll ask the supervisor, then update the customer through the store's usual contact channel.

05 • Cashier: Please don't say the exchange is approved just because the shopper has called twice.

06 • Incoming cashier: I won't. What response time was actually offered during the earlier call this afternoon?

07 • Cashier: They were promised an update by five, including if the review remained unfinished then.

08 • Incoming cashier: I've noted five as the update deadline. Is their preferred contact method already recorded?

09 • Cashier: Yes, in the customer record linked to R82; no need to repeat private details here.

10 • Incoming cashier: I'll handle that callback. You can mark the follow-up assigned to me, not resolved yet.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Handing over a till and an unfinished query

At shift change, the expected drawer balance is \$180 and the recorded count is \$175. A second check has not occurred, and the cause is unknown. A price query for item P32 also remains open. The incoming supervisor accepts both checks; do not accuse anyone or describe a loss as proved.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Incoming supervisor: accept the second cash check and item P32 price query as separate tasks.

Second round: Someone blames the prior cashier before the check. Keep the report factual without suggesting an unrecorded cash adjustment.

Scenario 2 | A till transfer and a missing acknowledgment

A cashier transferred a price-query record to the service desk but has no acknowledgment. The customer is waiting at lane two. The desk colleague can accept it now.

Role A: Outgoing cashier: confirm actual acceptance before leaving.

Role B: Service colleague: accept the query for item J18 and tell the customer where to wait.

Possible opening: I sent the query earlier; can you confirm you're handling it?

Success checks

- Distinguish sending from acceptance.
- Name J18 and the waiting location.
- Confirm who will give the next update.

Add a complication: The sender initially treats a sent message as a completed customer response.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Finding the item the shopper actually means

Editing example: Do you mean the cotton C218 or the linen L214?

The question identifies the ambiguity instead of giving uncertain directions.

Check 1: A - C218

A: Correct. C218 is the cotton item specified in the case.

B: L214 is the linen item, which the shopper excluded.

C: The shopper has identified only the cotton shirt.

D: The shopper explicitly said cotton rather than linen.

Check 2: D - stock-keeping unit

A: A size range lists available sizes rather than identifying one variation.

B: A product family can include multiple variations.

C: A department name identifies a broader store area.

D: Correct. The stock-keeping unit identifies the particular variation.

Model response: The advertisement shows two blue shirts, so let me check which one you mean. Is it the cotton shirt, code C218, in medium? Once we've confirmed that variation, I can check this store's stock. The picture alone doesn't tell us whether your size is available here today.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Comparing fit, materials, and label information

Editing example: The lined one requires dry cleaning; the other matches your machine-wash requirement.

The comparison uses the shopper's criterion rather than an undefined quality claim.

Check 1: D - Jacket A

A: Jacket B is labelled dry-clean only.

B: The care requirements differ between the jackets.

C: Jacket A does meet the stated care requirement.

D: Correct. Jacket A's label permits machine washing.

Check 2: C - lining

A: The outer shell is on the outside rather than inside.

B: A care label carries information, not the main inner layer.

C: Correct. A lining is the inner fabric layer.

D: A seam is a stitched join, not a fabric layer.

Model response: Both jackets are sixty dollars, but their care labels differ. Jacket A is unlined and labelled for machine washing; jacket B is lined and labelled dry-clean only. Since machine washing is your priority, A matches that stated requirement. You can still compare the fit before deciding.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Resolving shelf prices and offer conditions

Editing example: Two cost five under the offer; one alone costs three.

The quantity condition stays attached to the discounted price.

Check 1: C - three dollars

A: Five dollars is the two-bottle total.

B: That price is not stated anywhere in the offer.

C: Correct. The single-bottle price remains three dollars.

D: That is the average only when two qualifying bottles are bought.

Check 2: B - unit prices

A: Required purchase quantities alone do not give price per standard amount.

B: Correct. Unit prices use a common standard quantity.

C: Package totals alone can hide different pack sizes.

D: Discount percentages can start from different prices and do not establish cost per standard quantity.

Model response: The five-dollar offer applies when you buy two qualifying bottles. One bottle is still three dollars under these displayed terms. Two would average two dollars fifty each, but that average isn't the single-bottle price. Would you like one at three, or two qualifying bottles for five?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Checking the basket and payment status

Editing example: Payment hasn't started; I'll correct the duplicate entry before you pay.

A refund would imply money had already been paid.

Check 1: B - refund

A: Reviewing a subtotal also occurs before payment.

B: Correct. A refund returns money after payment; payment hasn't begun.

C: Checking quantity is part of this correction.

D: The screen can display the corrected price before payment.

Check 2: A - has not yet been taken

A: Correct. Correcting the basket does not complete the still-unpaid transaction.

B: A refund would return a payment, but none has been taken.

C: The shopper explicitly says payment has not happened yet.

D: This places payment before the correction, contradicting the stated sequence.

Model response: You're right: the basket shows two mugs, but you have one. I'm sorry about the duplicate scan. I'll correct the quantity before you pay. Your total is now eight dollars, with no additional charges. Please check that the screen shows one mug before we continue.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Discussing returns and exchanges at the counter

Editing example: The shirt qualifies for exchange; I'll check the larger size before confirming a replacement.

Eligibility alone does not establish local stock.

Check 1: A - exchange

A: Correct. An exchange replaces the purchased item with another.

B: Account credit is value for later use, not the requested replacement itself.

C: A reservation holds stock but does not replace a purchased item.

D: Cancelling an order is different from exchanging an already purchased shirt.

Check 2: D - value to spend at the store

A: A completed card refund returns money, which is a different arrangement.

B: Cash change is part of cash payment, not store credit.

C: The original payment is money paid to buy the item.

D: Correct. Store credit provides value usable at the store.

Model response: Your receipt shows the shirt was bought ten days ago. Under this store's stated terms, the unused shirt with its tags qualifies for an exchange within thirty days. We still need to check whether the larger size is here. I'll check that before we agree on the replacement.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Explaining local stock and collection status

Editing example: The order is acknowledged; one item is still being located.

The shopper receives the actual status instead of a broader implication.

Check 1: D - update

A: No dispatch is scheduled in this case.

B: The order has already been acknowledged; three is not a purchase appointment.

C: No refund has been agreed in this case.

D: Correct. The colleague promised new information at three.

Check 2: C - order acknowledgment

A: It does not confirm an item has arrived for collection.

B: It does not concern an exchange decision.

C: Correct. The message confirms that the order was received.

D: It does not identify any change of item.

Model response: That message confirms receipt of order R61; it isn't a collection notification. One item is still being located, so I can't say the order is ready. The collection colleague will update you at three, including if the search is unresolved. We won't substitute a different variation without asking you.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Managing queues and offering practical assistance

Editing example: Would you like help with your basket, or would you prefer to keep it?

The question gives the shopper control over the help offered.

Check 1: C - checkout access

A: No delivery arrangement has been requested by the shopper.

B: The shopper has not asked whether an item is stocked.

C: Correct. The shopper needs space at the payment point.

D: The shopper explicitly wants to keep and carry the bag.

Check 2: B - how you would like me to help

A: Place 'would' before 'like' in this indirect question.

B: Correct. The indirect question uses subject-verb order and 'me' after 'like'.

C: Use statement order after 'tell me': 'how you would like'.

D: Use the object form 'me' before the infinitive, not 'I'.

Model response: Lane four has the wider checkout space and is open now. Would you prefer directions or someone to accompany you? I'll ask my colleague to keep your place while we move the transaction. Please tell me what assistance you want; I won't assume you need help with your belongings.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Handing over a till and an unfinished query

Editing example: The first count is five dollars below the expected amount; the cause hasn't been established.

The revised report states the evidence without accusing anyone.

Check 1: B - five-dollar

A: That is the expected amount, not the difference.

B: Correct. The difference between the two figures is five dollars.

C: Ten does not match the subtraction of these figures.

D: That is the counted amount, not the difference.

Check 2: A - cancelled

A: Correct. A void cancels a transaction or item entry.

B: Reservation holds an item rather than cancelling a sale entry.

C: Delivery concerns physical movement, not a void entry.

D: Restocking concerns inventory and does not define a checkout void.

Model response: The first count is one hundred seventy-five dollars against an expected one hundred eighty, a five-dollar difference. The second check and cause are still open. Item P32 also has an unresolved price query. Please confirm you'll take both follow-ups and keep the two issues separate in the shift log.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All shops, transactions, stock records, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course covers frontline interactions, not retail strategy, merchandising management, financial advice, or universal consumer-law rules. Follow the employer's actual payment, privacy, safety, and returns procedures; refer exceptions and restricted decisions to the responsible staff.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Retail Sales Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/sales/retail-sales-workers.htm>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Cashiers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/sales/cashiers.htm>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Retail Associate and Cashier English

Professional audience: Retail sales associates, cashiers, fitting-room attendants, and shop-floor customer service staff

Scope: All shops, transactions, stock records, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course covers frontline interactions, not retail strategy, merchandising management, financial advice, or universal consumer-law rules. Follow the employer's actual payment, privacy, safety, and returns procedures; refer exceptions and restricted decisions to the responsible staff.

Lesson 01: Finding the item the shopper actually means

Original fictional case: A shopper asks for the blue shirt in an advertisement. The ad shows two blue shirts: linen L214 and cotton C218. The shopper wants a medium cotton shirt; local availability has not been checked. Confirm item and size before discussing stock.

Language workshop: Ask one question that narrows the search

Communication goal: Confirm product variation before searching for stock.

Language guidance: Color alone may describe several items. Use material, code, and size to distinguish them without claiming availability prematurely.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Do you mean the ___ or the ___? / The item code is ___; is that the one? / I'll check this store's stock in ___.

Vocabulary: stock-keeping unit: An identifier for a particular product variation, often abbreviated SKU, such as a specific shirt size and color. / barcode: A machine-readable pattern used to identify an item when scanned. / size range: The set of sizes in which a product is offered. / fitting room: A designated shop space where customers can try on clothing.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Shopper: want the medium cotton blue shirt, not the linen shirt; have not seen local stock information.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The shopper points at the wrong picture while repeating the cotton code. Clarify before searching.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The advertisement shows two blue shirts, so let me check which one you mean. Is it the cotton shirt, code C218, in medium? Once we've confirmed that variation, I can check this store's stock. The picture alone doesn't tell us whether your size is available here today.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Choose grammar that preserves the meaning

1. Use the lesson's language workshop, or one actual sentence from the dialogue, to explain a single grammar distinction in no more than 90 words. Show how it affects timing, certainty, responsibility or politeness.
2. Give one brief occupational exchange containing a gap and four complete options A-D. Supply enough context for exactly one answer. Keep distractors plausible; distinguish grammar errors from wording that changes the facts. Stop and wait.
3. Explain why each choice fits or fails, then ask me to read the completed exchange aloud. Do not request a draft, original written sentence or essay.
4. Repeat with three new exchanges, one at a time, moving from recognition to a more subtle meaning contrast. Do not copy the published checks. Label invented variations and do not turn uncertainty into a promise.
5. End with a short contrast table and two supported spoken turns using supplied frames. Accept accurate alternatives in oral practice; acknowledge and replace ambiguous multiple-choice items.

END PROMPT

Choose a clear message

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

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When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Coach guided workplace message choices

1. Use only the supplied reference and create one short, realistic dialogue with professional role labels and exactly one missing word or phrase. Supply four distinct options labelled A-D. Ensure that exactly one option fits both the grammar and the stated facts. Do not request a draft, an essay, or any open-ended writing. Stop and wait for my choice.
2. Use plausible distractors based on word combinations, certainty, timing, responsibility, or register. Avoid obviously absurd options. Do not introduce an unverified diagnosis, approval, deadline, charge, or legal rule. If extra fictional facts are necessary, state them explicitly before asking the question.
3. After I choose, identify the correct option and explain briefly why each of the other three options does not fit this exchange. Quote the relevant case fact or wording. Invite me to read both roles aloud; do not claim to assess pronunciation from a typed response.
4. Offer another four-choice exchange that practices a different expression. Present only one question at a time, wait for my answer, and vary the correct letter. If more than one answer is defensible, acknowledge the ambiguity and replace the question rather than marking a reasonable choice wrong.
5. After four exchanges, recap two useful word combinations and one distinction I should revisit. Ask which supported scenario I want to rehearse next, then stop and wait.

END PROMPT